

STRESS SPIRAL

Chronic stress affects sleep, appetite, glucose regulation, digestion, and hormonal signalling. When we are persistently in fight-or-flight mode, digestion is hardly the body's priority. Altered gut motility and digestive function can lead to bloating and dysbiosis. Poor sleep then worsens appetite and glucose control, and the cycle perpetuates itself. What begins as "I'm just stressed" can eventually present as abdominal weight gain, poor energy, cravings, disturbed sleep, and worsening cardiometabolic markers.

This is why walking, resistance training, yoga, meditation, breath work, nature, and meaningful relationships aren't lifestyle decorations. They are part of preventive medicine.

THE LONGEVITY PRESCRIPTION

Living in an Indian metropolis, we cannot completely control what we breathe or encounter. Research increasingly associates air pollution with cardiovascular, metabolic, and neurological disease, while systematic-review evidence has linked exposure to heavy metals like lead, mercury, arsenic, and cadmium with metabolic syndrome.

We can reduce—not eliminate—our burden: Use effective air filtration during severe pollution, avoid smoking, minimise unnecessary chemical exposures, wash produce well, choose cleaner food sources, and drink reliably filtered, mineral-adequate water.

THE GUT FEELING

Our intestine is where food meets the immune system, microbes, and environment. A resilient microbiome helps metabolise fibre into short-chain fatty acids, communicates with immune pathways, and participates in the gut-brain axis. That makes chronic bloating, constipation, reflux, and food intolerance worth investigating rather than normalising.

We should eat fermented foods and diverse fibres where tolerated, but there is an important clinical caveat: More fibre and more probiotics are not automatically better for everyone. Someone with SIBO or significant dysbiosis can feel considerably worse. Longevity medicine should be personalised.

Also, no supplement can "detox" excessive drinking into a longevity habit. Alcohol is linked to several cancers. The liver, gut, brain, and heart all count the exposure even when our social calendar doesn't.

EARLY INSIGHTS

Modern longevity medicine now focusses on detecting trajectory rather than waiting for diagnosis. Metabolic health assessments like age-appropriate bone density, cardiovascular, and cancer screenings are crucial, as are hormonal tests. The purpose isn't to turn healthy people into anxious patients but to urge them to measure intelligently, intervene early, and then get on with living.

The science of longevity is becoming extraordinarily sophisticated, yet some of its most compelling lessons remain ancient. Eat real food. Build muscle. Move throughout the day. Sleep deeply. Don't smoke or drink. Protect the gut. Know your metabolic numbers. Spend time outdoors. Give yourselves reasons to wake up interested in tomorrow. Because ultimatelym the new luxury isn't simply time—it is having more good years in which to enjoy it. ■

Clockwise from facing page: Chiva-Som Hua Hin Wellness Resort offers a host of treatments immersed in nature; the revitalisation programme at Clinique La Prairie in Montreux, Switzerland is a popular cellular therapy among global A-listers; at Hotel Capo d'Orso Thalasso & Spa, one can enjoy a range of hydro therapies